

Science of Indifference

A Calm Way to Quit Smoking — and More



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[Science of Indifference — Marat Bekmurzaev](#)

Introduction

Dear reader, take this book seriously. Think of it as a practical tool — an alternative to visiting a psychotherapist when it comes to changing habits. You will not find miraculous promises of “instant results” or “your last cigarette forever.” What you will find is an honest method, grounded in statistical research and personal experience, that shows how to give up tobacco without suffering, without guilt, and without illusions.

- **Goal:** to present quitting smoking as the process of forming a new habit — the habit of indifference.
- **Distinction:** the focus is not on fighting nicotine itself, but on changing the way you relate to it.
- **Promise:** ease instead of struggle, honesty instead of slogans, indifference instead of dependence.
- **Main message:** all existing methods of quitting — hypnosis, patches, breathing techniques, books, challenges, motivational courses — are fragments of a larger process. At its core, quitting is about changing the habit.
- **Practical note:** for deeper immersion and to engage the subconscious, I would recommend contributing an amount equal to the cost of several packs of cigarettes. Our minds naturally seek to justify the resources we invest. That said, those who genuinely need help are not required to do this — the book is free. Still, the better path is to give it further life: share it with someone who needs it, write a recommendation, or leave a review.

This method shows how different approaches fit together into a single system, gives each one its proper place, and turns them into a complete understanding and a practical skill: quitting nicotine.

Author

Chapter 1. Scientific Summary

1. Research

- BMJ Open (2016), University of Toronto
- Long-term study of thousands of smokers

2. Numbers

- Probability of success on the first attempt: about 11%
- On later attempts, the rate drops to 5% or lower
- Average number of attempts before success: around 30 (more precisely, 29.6 according to the study)
- The range can extend up to 140 attempts (142 in the study's data)

3. Conclusions

- Quitting smoking is not a single act, but a process of many attempts. It is not “quit once and for all.”
- Each attempt builds the skill of quitting, even if it ends in relapse.
- The number “30” is an average, not a rule, but statistically it reflects the experience of most readers.
- Dialectics: the gentler the path, the more attempts it may take — but with less suffering.

4. Practical Meaning

- Slogans like “right now and forever” contradict the evidence.
- Failures and relapses are normal, ordinary — just another Monday — not a sign of weakness.
- Any method must account for both repetition and individuality.

Chapter 2. In the beginning there were numbers

I should begin by saying that I started smoking as soon as I entered military school. Before that, I did it hesitantly, sneaking cigarettes from my father one at a time. But the military environment stripped away any shyness, and I began smoking openly, almost as a performance. That display quickly turned into a strange kind of pride.

Looking back now, I feel embarrassed. At the time, though, I treated it as a matter of principle — principles I now calmly recognize as foolish. For example, I insisted on smoking only strong cigarettes in red packs. And with the same “principled stance,” I loudly — and, in truth, foolishly — declared that I intended to smoke for the rest of my life.

Yet, to be honest, deep down I still dreamed of quitting — as every smoker does. The truth is, I didn’t like the smoke. I didn’t like spending money on it. And I didn’t like that the people I cared about turned away from me.

Sometimes I even made attempts that looked like quitting, but they were so weak that I never followed through. Remembering them now makes me ashamed. In short, I was convinced that cigarettes would be my companions for life.

And then, in 2016, just when I was completely certain that everything was lost, I stumbled upon an article. In their usual loud style, the journalists proclaimed: “Canadians have discovered the secret to quitting smoking.”

This article caught my attention — not because it was yet another journalistic “breakthrough,” but because it was backed by science. The method was based on data from a long-term study in which researchers observed thousands of smokers over several years. Their aim was to determine the actual number of attempts needed to successfully quit tobacco.

The article included the following details:

Key findings of the study — the average number of attempts before successfully quitting was about 30.

The range varied: for some people it could be as few as 5, while for others it reached as high as 142.

“What nonsense,” I thought at the time. “And what about all those claims that ‘two or three or five attempts are enough if you really try’? No, something doesn’t add up here.”

Reading the article didn’t inspire me — on the contrary, it upset me. So much so that on that day I became even more convinced: I would smoke for the rest of my life.

But later, after cooling down, I realized there was real meaning in those numbers.

At the time I still didn't understand what most smokers overlook — that smoking is not just a psychological habit. It is driven by the biochemical effects of nicotine.

Here I'll allow myself a brief digression to share my view on this belief. The logic of quitting is almost always framed around the slogan "you need willpower." But if you think about it, willpower as motivation has no real foundation without gradual action.

So I realized there was, in principle, nothing to be upset about. And later, once I had quit and explored the nature of the human psyche, memory, and perception, it became clearer to me why such variation exists.

Reasons for the variation:

For some smokers, fewer attempts are recorded because they tend to have stricter discipline, weaker memory, or stronger motivation and organization.

For others, the number of attempts is higher because they choose the easiest and most "comfortable" path, where each attempt is not seen as a failure but as a small experiment. This path takes longer, but it is less painful.

Simply put, a smoker who takes this approach may not even stop using tobacco right away, but instead follows a kind of "game of postponement," stretching the process step by step. That is how I did it myself — as the author of this model — when I went through the same path. I will explain this method later.

The important point is this: whether it takes thirty attempts, one hundred forty, or even five — the number alone does not determine the outcome. What matters is the depth of involvement. That is why thirty attempts can equal one hundred forty or five: the measure is not the count, but the level of engagement of the person who is quitting.

When the process is broken into many small, easy steps, it takes longer, but creates a sense of simplicity and naturalness. On the other hand, shorter and more concentrated effort deepens immersion, strengthens the impact, and naturally increases inner conflict.

This is why it is important to keep both direction and goal — what people usually call willpower. It doesn't matter whether the path is short or long: the essential thing is not to stop, but to keep moving forward.

Even if the "easy path" is chosen, the effort must continue. It's a mistake to think the process no longer concerns you. On the contrary, you must stay aware of it at all times: constant attention and determination are what make the method effective.

So the number of attempts is not a sign of strength or weakness, but a reflection of the chosen strategy and personal psychology.

Here, **memory and self-reflection** play an important role: some record every attempt, even brief ones, while others note only serious periods of quitting.

Chapter 3. How the Method Was Created

I can't recall exactly how much time passed after reading that article in the media, but something in it kept troubling me.

After a short while, I found the article again and went on to study the scientists' report.

My first careful reading and analysis confirmed a simple idea: quitting smoking is not a single act, but a series of attempts. Each one matters, and when there are many attempts, there is no reason to worry about failures.

I remember spending two or three months reflecting on this discovery: "But all doctors and psychologists say it's hard. And then there are these thirty attempts..."

Then one day I had an insight: it is the multiplicity of attempts that shapes the habit of refusal. This realization became the foundation of my approach — in the process of quitting, a relapse should not be seen as a failure; it is part of the ongoing sequence of relapses that gradually change one's attitude toward nicotine.

I had always seen myself as a realist, and often as a person of weak disposition. Not in the sense of being insignificant, but in the sense that I never knew how to force myself to do what was "necessary" if I didn't truly want it inside.

At the same time, there were moments in life when I did things that surprised not only those around me, but also myself. Perhaps what mattered was that I understood my limits soberly and didn't build illusions

Therefore, I was more convinced that I would smoke for the rest of my life than that I would ever give up cigarettes. I approached quitting in a methodical, evidence-based way, but without much hope. And yet I quit — surprising both myself and those around me — because the result came much sooner than I expected.

In other words, this honest admission of weakness worked in my favor: I didn't try to display strength where it wasn't there, and I didn't promise myself the impossible.

So then, about three months later, my vague suspicions finally crystallized into a clear and definite thought:

1. Quitting smoking is not a one-time act, but a process made up of multiple attempts.

Quitting smoking doesn't happen in a single day and can't be reduced to one decision. It isn't an instant act of willpower, but a process built from many steps and repeated attempts.

In my mind the thought sounded more vivid, but the essence was the same: quitting smoking is a Sisyphean task — only with guaranteed success.

Each time a person refuses a cigarette, it's as if he's pushing a stone up a slope. The stone may roll back down, but every attempt strengthens the skill of resistance. And unlike the ancient Greek hero, the smoker eventually carries the stone to the top — as long as he doesn't abandon the effort.

The habit of smoking forms quickly, often in just a few weeks. But breaking it takes much longer: one must dismantle not only the chemical dependence, but also the entire social framework built around it.

And here it becomes clear: mere willpower is nothing more than an empty slogan.

It only comes alive when it turns into steps, practice, and repeated attempts. Desire alone means nothing. A person can want to fly to the point of frenzy, but without knowledge, preparation, and the skill of controlling the wing, that desire will remain just a dream.

A long walk — that is the exact metaphor. Each step is a small refusal: not smoking in the morning, postponing a cigarette for ten minutes, for two minutes, for twenty seconds. It may seem insignificant, but it is precisely such steps that gradually change one's inner attitude toward smoking.

And even if refusal doesn't happen completely, the very act of delaying, reducing the number, or shifting the time is already movement. It is already part of the process.

From this comes the understanding: quitting smoking is impossible in a single leap. It is a path where every step matters, where multiplicity becomes the foundation of success.

Out of this was born the second conclusion.

2. Each attempt helps form the habit of refusal, even if it doesn't end in complete victory.

An unsuccessful attempt is not a failure. It doesn't define a person, nor does it stigmatize them as "weak" or "inadequate." On the contrary, it reflects the strength of involvement, showing that the process is underway, that movement continues — that the person strives and does not let go.

These failures become part not of a difficult, but of a long and wearisome process — the Path. They don't nullify the effort, but instead accumulate into a shared reservoir of experience. Each cigarette postponed even for a few minutes, each day with fewer smoked than usual — this is a step. Small, but real.

That's why, in changing a habit, the clearest analogy is the road. You can't instantly be ten kilometers away just by stepping out the door, as some "teachers" and "experts" like to promise. The road requires steps. And each step strengthens the skill of resistance, making it a little more familiar, a little more natural.

Thus the habit of refusal is formed — through multiplicity, through repetition, through the honest admission that the path consists of many episodes. Not of one heroic leap, but of dozens serious and focused, hundreds thoughtful, and thousands of small attempts.

And it is precisely this multiplicity that gradually changes the inner attitude toward nicotine. At first it seems that nothing is changing, that everything goes in circles. But over time the circles become a spiral: each new turn lifts you a little higher, gives a little more confidence, a little more freedom.

3. The number “30” is an average guideline, not a rule.

The figure of thirty doesn’t mark a magical boundary or a mandatory condition — it’s only an average indicator. Reality may be shorter or longer: some manage in seventeen attempts, others in thirty-five, and for some the process stretches to a hundred or more. There are rare exceptions — people who quit in five or even two attempts. But that is a statistical minimum, not a rule. And it is precisely such stories that turn into myth: they are presented as heroic examples, and we hear the familiar refrain — “He could, and you can too.”

It’s important to understand that this number reflects statistics, not the path of any particular person. Scientists record an average value made up of many individual stories. So if your own result is close to thirty, it simply means you fall within the range of the majority — strangely enough.

But if it turns out differently, that’s no reason to see yourself as an exception or a “failure.”

What matters is recognizing that each attempt counts. Even if it doesn’t end in complete refusal, it still adds to the overall tally, helps form the habit of resistance, and gradually changes the attitude toward nicotine. This is the meaning of the number “30”: it shows that the process requires time and repetition, not a single heroic effort.

This number may concern you personally, dear reader, if you follow the path conscientiously and attentively. Perhaps your own trials will show something close to thirty attempts — give or take. But this is not dogma.

The essence lies not in the exact number, but in the fact that you keep moving forward.

For most people, changing such a strong habit as smoking truly takes about thirty serious steps. What matters most here is sincerity toward oneself and one’s inner “I.”

If you are honest with yourself, if you admit weakness and keep trying, then any number — twenty, thirty, or even one hundred thirty — becomes part of your path.

Timeframes and numbers matter only when it’s possible to measure the depth of personal experience. But such technologies don’t exist: no one will ever tell you that you need exactly twenty-three attempts or forty-five hours of meditation. It is always an individual path.

4. The dialectics of the process: the softer and simpler the path, the more attempts it may take — but the less suffering and psychological trauma.

I quit smoking three to four years after I understood the meaning of the work. And it happened easily, almost naturally: I simply told myself, “I don’t want to! Ugh!” — and that was it.

Later I realized that in twenty-five years of smoking I had spent only two days without cigarettes. This discovery surprised me no less than the act of quitting itself. After all, I had always believed smoking was part of my life and never even tried to build illusions that I could quit.

My approach was always simple and drawn-out. I chose not struggle, but a gradual reevaluation of values, even though it was riskier. It was a path without heroism or strain, a path of questionable good and possible unexpected consequences.

Each day I tried to light up a little later than usual, delaying the moment for any reason I could find. And if something didn't work out, I didn't torment myself — I simply took a cigarette and moved on.

Thus, step by step, my personal experience took shape.

I never set strict deadlines, never appointed due dates, and never promised myself miracles. My inner attitudes were simple: "someday later" and "if it happens."

And when refusal finally came, I didn't even realize it at first. My first thought was: "Already? So soon?!" After all, I had prepared myself for a much longer journey.

For me it was a surprise, because I was used to a long path and expected the result to come much later.

Only afterward did I conduct a personal analysis, which showed that my serious attempts at refusal were not thirty, as the studies suggest, but about one hundred thirty. And this was a conscious, relaxed understanding of the path, where multiplicity was not seen as defeat, but as the natural course of things.

My experience — and the experience of others — proved that the true method of giving up nicotine is built not on a "miracle of willpower," but on the statistically confirmed necessity of multiplicity and of an individual approach.

Chapter 4. Practical Meaning

Before speaking about how easily and simply one can cope with abstinence — “quit with indifference,” and in general refuse with the help of one interesting method, the “method of pleasure” — let us once again recall and affirm: the slogans “at once and forever” contradict the facts.

Human psychology will always search for the possibility of a “magic pill” or a “fairy-tale gymnastics,” just to ease the inner demand to give the brain a little nicotine.

It is natural to choose the simplest path. And this is precisely what is exploited by those who profit from the weakness of others.

This narrative is also reinforced by popular “gurus,” bloggers, and other authorities — for personal gain. Every year books, trainings, and slogans appear, most of them built on the promise of instant liberation: “Read — and you will quit,” “Believe — and forever.”

These promises sound appealing, but they contradict the facts.

Moreover, it’s reasonable to assume that this narrative is also used by the tobacco companies themselves. After all, the myth that one can quit “once and forever” with a single act of will is the most profitable for them. It is precisely the tobacco lobby that finds it convenient to shape medical and psychological practices where the main thesis resounds as this categorical “Never!”

Together with a striking Hollywood frame, where Keanu Reeves as John Constantine dies of lung cancer and the devil gives him a second chance, pulling the tumors straight out of his body. In that moment the hero quits smoking immediately — easily, instantly, without effort.

The viewer admires his strength and subconsciously thinks: “If only I could do the same — remove all disease and all filth from the lungs in one miracle. Then I too could quit at once.”

But this is cinema!

In reality, no one will come and pull the tumors out of the lungs. In reality, a person returns to the pack again — and realizes that in this case there is nothing left but to rely on a miracle.

If I were a cigarette manufacturer, the first thing I would do is study real methods of refusal, investing the necessary sums. And once I had clarified the scientific nature of smoking, I would begin investing in the creation of the myth — “Quit now and forever!” And everyone would hear only that there are people who quit easily.

Reality, however, is far more prosaic: quitting smoking is a process made up of many attempts. And each of them matters.

The illusion of “at once and forever” makes the process invisible, devalues the small steps, and turns natural failures into guilt.

That’s why the practical meaning of my method begins with destroying this illusion. It must be said honestly: quitting smoking in a single leap is almost impossible. But quitting through multiplicity — through the gradual formation of the habit of refusal — that is real.

In other words, you will not quit at once. **Accept this as fact.**

Of course, it should be reminded that there will always be a vanishingly small number of smokers who quit cigarettes instantly — whether due to their unique psyche or years of inner work. But, I repeat, this is precisely that minority which wins lotteries, is saved by dolphins, or walks away without a scratch from monstrous catastrophes.

And against this contrast another phenomenon becomes especially noticeable: many people who have quit smoking turn their achievement into a reason to elevate themselves above others.

I think almost every smoker has met someone who arrogantly declared: “I managed — so what, are you weak?”

These words always sound like a reproach, like a show of strength, but in reality they only create extra pressure and a sense of guilt.

Unfortunately, few understand that what matters here is not displaying one’s significance, but cultivating the normalization of multiplicity. For it is precisely multiplicity that makes the process honest and realistic: each attempt is part of the path, not a failure. Every cigarette postponed even for a few minutes, and every day with fewer smoked than usual — that is a step. Small, but real.

When I smoked, my father — then still alive — often said: “I quit. You should try too!”

I tried to understand his methods and approaches, but I ran into vague phrases: “Just do it” or “Don’t stop.” These words sounded right, but they didn’t explain how exactly to act, what not to stop at, or how to calmly develop the habit of refusal.

But when I finally quit, the first thing I told him was that his method — and it truly was a working method — should be supplemented with one important phrase: “You will not quit at once, but little by little, step by step — you will quit. Just work. Just don’t stop.”

This thought is the key to normalizing multiplicity. It removes the illusion of instant success, takes away the guilt of failure, and turns each attempt into a brick in the common foundation. In this way a new habit is formed — the habit of refusal, built not on miracle, but on honesty and repetition.

It is important to understand that failures and relapses are not weakness, but a norm — a statistical given.

They do not erase the path or cancel the intention; they enter into the overall process as natural events. A relapse is not a “minus to character,” but a signal: showing where exactly it catches you, in which contexts and states the craving intensifies, and which situations demand separate attention. The more honestly we recognize these points, the more precisely we can adjust the next steps.

That is why this method offers no clear universal plan “for everyone.” You only need to choose from the many ways of fighting nicotine — those that suit you personally — and begin to try. Here pure freedom of creativity is allowed: you assemble your own set of actions like a personal toolkit, test small changes, keep what works, and calmly discard what doesn’t. Ultimatums are unnecessary — what matters are consistent, realizable steps.

The method recognizes that each person has their own psychological stimuli, habits, and worldview. Therefore it should be analyzed and practiced as individual work — personally and honestly. Not

under someone else's scenario, but in your own rhythm: your triggers, your "weak spots," your daily contexts. The point is not to "fit" into a strict program, but to tune the process of refusal so that it is calm and manageable precisely for you.

In other words, one smoker may cope with the craving for a cigarette through sheer willpower, another through distracting actions; someone may need a mentor, guide, or supervisor, while for another the best solution might be psychotherapy or even hypnosis — if resources allow. Each has their own path, their own tools, their own emphases.

In short, everything here is individual. There is no universal formula, no single recipe. There is only the work — honest, consistent, and directed toward step-by-step formation of the habit of refusal. And it is precisely in this work that the practical meaning of the method lies: it grants freedom of choice and the possibility to build your own route, one that will work specifically for you.

Here it is worth pausing to speak about the ethical side of the work:

Quitting smoking does not demand heroism or painful struggle — it demands honesty with oneself.

Even if the path turns out to be long and stretches across dozens or even a hundred attempts, it will not become shorter if you engage in self-deception.

The subconscious cannot be deceived: morning promises such as "this is my last cigarette forever," without the proper mindset, do not work. It not only rejects such tricks because it senses falseness — it begins to play against us if it sees that we are acting insincerely.

But it does accept sincere effort — when a person tells themselves, "I will try to do it for real," and truly tries. Moreover, the subconscious can show its character and even express disagreement through external signs such as panic attacks, rashes, or other manifestations of psychosomatic disorders.

Only the honesty of intentions disarms our inner "I." Honesty turns even a long path into a simple road toward indifference. It removes unnecessary pathos, takes away guilt, and makes each step transparent. Honesty is the foundation on which the new habit is built: the habit of refusal.

Using the method as an excuse will only prolong the process. If you tell yourself, "I am working by the method, therefore everything is going right," but at the same time do not take real steps, then this becomes mere self-soothing. The method works only when it becomes personal practice — when you honestly record your attempts and continue to move forward.

Chapter 5. The Essence of the Method

Attention! When quitting smoking, you don't need to change your environment, hide cigarettes, or avoid familiar places. Such "protection" only increases the significance of the habit and turns it into a forbidden fruit. Indifference is formed precisely in the natural environment — where smoking once happened, where the cigarette lies in plain sight, where the smell and ritual are familiar. A person learns to walk calmly past, to see the cigarette as an empty object, not as a challenge. This is not struggle and not avoidance, but gradual habituation to the absence of reaction. The environment becomes a training ground, not an enemy.

Dear reader, this chapter is the heart of the entire book. Here lies the foundation for which all the previous pages were written. It is here that we arrive at the main point: the principles that make quitting smoking not a painful feat, but a calm and natural process.

That is why it is especially important to focus your attention now.

Do not rush. Read slowly, thoughtfully.

It is best to take a pen and write down everything said here in your own words.

This is not a formality: when you put a thought on paper, a special kind of memory switches on — manual, through the hand. It helps not only to hear an idea, but to live it, to anchor it inside yourself.

Do not be surprised if you notice repetitions. They are intentional.

Repetition is a way to fix meaning, to turn it into a habit. After all, quitting smoking means replacing one habit with another. And for the new habit to take root, you need to hear it, understand it, realize it, and live it not just a few times, but dozens and hundreds of times.

Any habit is formed through dozens and hundreds of repetitions. Writing only strengthens understanding and helps make repetition natural.

The method you hold in your hands is built on three principles and one key skill.

It is not a dry formula or an abstract scheme, but a living foundation worth keeping in mind.

It is simple — and it is precisely in this simplicity that its strength lies.

These principles and the skill are all that is needed for the journey: direction, support, and the ability to walk. With them you can move through the entire path and reach the main goal — independence and indifference to nicotine. With pauses, with rest, and with enjoyment of the process itself.

This comparison is not accidental. Quitting smoking is not a leap, but a path.

And to walk it, you need not miracles or heroism, but simple and reliable supports.

The principles and the skill become exactly such supports: they help you move forward step by step, without straying from the road and without losing confidence.

And the essence of this path is very simple.

Principle No. 1. First, it is necessary to accept the fact of craving and not dramatize it.

Craving for nicotine is not merely a “weakness” or a “bad habit.” It is a socio-cultural, deeply rooted pattern of behavior transmitted for decades through television screens, book pages, and even cartoons. The cigarette has become part of imagery — a symbol of adulthood, freedom, or style — and this cultural layer has firmly settled in the collective consciousness.

Beneath this cultural layer lies another, neighboring stimulus: biochemical.

Through it nicotine acts directly on the brain, on the reward system, and it is precisely here that the hook is formed which keeps a person dependent.

We will discuss cultural and psychological mechanisms a little later — for now it is important to understand the biology of this craving itself.

In essence, nicotine penetrates the brain within seconds of a puff. It binds to nicotinic acetylcholine receptors located in areas responsible for the reward system. In response, dopamine is released — the very “pleasure hormone” the brain interprets as a signal of reward.

That is why each puff feels like a small gift, as if the body has received something precious.

But this reward is deceptive. Nicotine is quickly broken down and stops acting, while the receptors demand new stimulation to trigger another surge of dopamine. Thus the cycle is formed: puff — pleasure — decline — new craving.

Over time, tolerance develops: the receptors become less sensitive, and to achieve the same sensation, more nicotine is required. As a result, the usual cigarette stops bringing pleasure, yet the brain still demands it, because the reward mechanism has already been rewritten by dependence.

The real trick is that addiction is formed not at the level of “weak will,” but much deeper — in the very biochemistry of the brain.

Nicotine acts instantly: within seconds it reaches the brain. There it binds to receptors responsible for transmitting signals of pleasure. These receptors trigger the release of dopamine, and a person feels a brief surge of joy, as if receiving a small reward. But it is precisely in this speed that the treachery lies: the brain instantly learns to connect the puff with pleasure.

If we compare it with other habits — such as eating or exercising — the reward comes later: one must eat, digest, or train before feeling the result. But nicotine gives an “answer” immediately. It is like pressing a button of instant gratification. And the brain, designed to seek quick pleasures, begins to reinforce this pattern much faster than any other.

Gradually, sensitivity decreases, and to trigger the same surge of dopamine, more nicotine is required. This is called tolerance. Yet the paradox is that even when pleasure diminishes, the

mechanism “puff = reward” remains. The brain has already rewritten its algorithms: it expects the signal, even if the signal itself has become empty.

That is why nicotine addiction develops rapidly — just a few weeks of regular smoking are enough for the brain’s biochemistry to consolidate dependence.

And it is precisely this speed that makes nicotine one of the most treacherous substances: it deceives the brain, promising joy, but leaves only an empty habit that gradually begins to control the person.

But biochemistry is only part of the picture. Dependence is formed not only in the body, but also in behavior.

Nicotine’s action affects not just biochemistry, but social and behavioral scenarios.

Smoking becomes fixed not only as chemical dependence, but also as ritual. “A cigarette with coffee,” “a cigarette at work,” “a cigarette under stress” — these scenes repeat again and again, turning into familiar images.

Each such association becomes a trigger: a person reaches for a cigarette not for nicotine itself, but for the act, for the feeling of familiar order.

Over time, smoking begins to be perceived as part of identity. It becomes a sign of adulthood, a way to emphasize style, or even a means of coping with emotions. This is where the strength of the cultural layer lies: it makes dependence not only biological, but also psychological.

Here the social factor is especially important. Smoke breaks with colleagues, conversations “over a cigarette,” the feeling of belonging to a group — all of this reinforces dependence. A person smokes not only because the brain demands nicotine, but also because smoking is woven into their social ties. It turns into a language of communication, a familiar bridge between people.

Thus dependence is sustained on two levels simultaneously: biochemical and cultural. One grips the body, the other grips consciousness and social habits. That is why smoking seems so persistent: it is anchored in the brain, in culture, and in everyday rituals.

And so, the first principle is the **recognition of craving**.

This is precisely where the method strikes the mark: no heroism is required, no self-deception.

One must honestly acknowledge the craving, stop dramatizing it, and gradually cultivate indifference.

Biochemistry provides the hook, while psychology fixes it into habit. But if both layers are addressed simultaneously, the craving ceases to be a “forbidden fruit” and gradually dissipates.

Craving is a natural signal of the body, not an enemy.

When a person stops fighting against themselves and acknowledges its existence, the tension decreases.

Acceptance transforms craving from a “catastrophe” into an ordinary phenomenon that can be calmly endured.

And if one continues to calmly work on changing the habit, step by step, the result becomes inevitable. One simple and easy rule applies: **do not stop**. Even the smallest steps add up to movement, and movement is always stronger than stagnation.

To make this path easier, it is worth recalling the main source of suffering — prohibitions.

It is precisely prohibitions that turn natural craving into drama. They create the illusion of struggle, where every step seems like defeat and every puff like catastrophe. But in reality, prohibitions themselves are the very specter that fuels dependence.

I came to understand that quitting smoking is possible only when one stops fighting prohibitions. The true opponent here is the narrative: “Quit forever!”, “Right now!”, “Don’t smoke!”, “Never touch it again!”.

These directives act like hooks, intensify dependence, and turn the cigarette into a mythical “forbidden fruit,” while quitting itself acquires a halo of fantasy.

Science and statistics contradict these theses: studies show that strict prohibitions and slogans rarely lead to lasting results.

On the contrary, the data confirm that cessation becomes reliable only through gradual behavioral restructuring, multiple attempts, and the cultivation of indifference to the habit. When a person confronts the reality of their relapses and learns to perceive them calmly, the probability of long-term success is significantly higher than with a single “jerk” under the pressure of prohibition.

It is enough to acknowledge the fact of craving “here” and “now,” allow yourself to light a cigarette, exhale, and release all those obligations imposed by no one in particular — and relief comes immediately.

This is not surrender, but an honest recognition of reality.

The mechanism here is the same as in love and passion. The more distant and forbidden the romantic interest, the more strongly it is surrounded by an aura of desirability.

I am certain everyone has experienced this: when a feeling seemed unreachable, it became almost perfect, wrapped in the glow of fantasy. Yet once you draw closer or gain favor, it suddenly turns out that the idealized image is not so wonderful, and the miracle dissolves.

This is familiar to most, because we have all fallen in love.

The same happens with smoking. Prohibitions create around the cigarette an aura of the “forbidden fruit,” intensifying its appeal. But once the myth is removed, once it is acknowledged as an ordinary phenomenon, the aura dissipates. Then the habit loses its power: the person retains control and moves toward indifference.

Second principle. Working with relapses

We have already understood that relapses are normal. Now let us talk about how to work with “relapses”.

It must be clarified right away: there are different paths of struggle. There is the well-known path of endurance and heroism — the path of titans and knights, praised in bloggers’ odes, carved into tablets by coaches, and staged as epic mysteries and hysterias by snake-oil sellers. And somewhere in the dark depths of tobacco corporations spreads the rumor of “walking on water” and great retribution.

And there are many paths for you — an ordinary person, just like everyone around.

No one forbids you to take the road of heroism and push too hard. But we are simpler people; we understand the principles of working with habit. We are armed with the most important weapon of success — knowledge. Therefore...

First of all, we calmly and with pleasure light a cigarette. As a second step, we inwardly accept the fact that on the thirtieth, hundredth, or two-hundredth occasion you may suddenly catch yourself thinking: “I do not want to smoke.”

Until that moment arrives, it is important to relax and stop experiencing inner conflict when, in the process of quitting, the inevitable urges and demands of the brain appear.

Be prepared for the fact that the brain will inevitably deceive you. And the harder you try to endure, the more insistently it will demand.

Here one simple trick helps. By postponing the moment of taking tobacco — “for five minutes, until something more important” — you launch the game of “just a little longer.” Its essence is to delay the moment until a specific trigger: a time, a result, a goal. It resembles a debtor who keeps extending the deadline for “repaying the debt.” With sufficient practice, the game can last for hours, sometimes almost the entire day. In it the brain gradually loses its power, while you acquire resilience.

This technique helped me personally as well. I did not suffer or feel guilt when the brain “won”: I calmly lit up and with a smirk told myself, “You won, scoundrel!”

In Allen Carr's methodological approach there is a very important idea: if one looks closely at the body's demand for a dose, it becomes clear that withdrawal is purely psychological in nature. The proof is simple — smokers do not get up at night to smoke. They calmly endure periods without a cigarette, sometimes even longer than it seems: long flights, hours-long court hearings, hospital stays, exams, business meetings, concerts, or theater performances.

All these situations demonstrate one thing: the body is capable of functioning without nicotine far longer than the habit suggests. A person does not experience genuine physiological withdrawal; he merely encounters the psychological expectation of "I must light up." But when circumstances exclude such a possibility, the expectation dissolves on its own.

And when you play with the brain as the "negligent debtor," an involuntary reordering of priorities takes place. "Well, just a little... you said five minutes ago you would give... twenty... twenty-five" — the brain demands, but you continue to play at the same level. It is precisely in this game that resilience is born, quietly and naturally. After all, no one is forcing you not to smoke — you are simply playing. And losing here is not a catastrophe, but a natural process that becomes a reward to your "demanding" self, to the body, and to the brain.

And note — this is not yet the actual methods that will be discussed later (although this way of working is one of the most effective). The point here is what truly matters for quitting smoking: to work.

Work methodically, step by step, moving directly toward the goal. Slowly, gently.

If the "negligent debtor" method does not suit you, and substitutions with other stimuli — candies, gum — work better, then move in that direction. The point is to keep working: even if you light up, it is not a failure, but merely a data point in the statistics that lead toward indifference.

It is important to see yourself not as a loser, but as a participant on the path. Each attempt strengthens the skill of abstaining, even if it does not end in complete victory.

Relapses are part of the process; they are built into the very logic of quitting.

A relapse during the work does not nullify your efforts; it becomes an element of the statistics, a confirmation that movement continues. It shows that a person is in the process, that he is working, that his attention is directed toward the goal.

Each relapse is not a defeat, but a step that adds experience. A relapse marks the point where the habit is still strong, and it is precisely this knowledge that helps to build the next steps.

Thus, relapses in the work are not weakness, but part of the method. They confirm that the process is underway, that the habit is gradually losing its power, and that the person is strengthening the skill of abstaining step by step. Smoke with enjoyment, because this is...

Third principle. Enjoying the process

When I realized that quitting smoking is inevitably connected with numerous procedures requiring effort and tension, the first condition I set for myself was not to turn the process into martyrdom.

And how can one avoid experiencing all the “delights” of anxiety, self-punishment, and stoic endurance?

Above all, it must be remembered: quitting smoking is psychological work, not physical withdrawal.

You will not experience real suffering like alcoholics or drug addicts do.

The entire syndrome of nicotine hunger boils down to the demands of the brain: inner tension, salivation, anxiety, and unfamiliar discomfort. Yet once you distract yourself, immerse in a process, or simply fall asleep — the craving retreats. Therefore, the key task is to learn to soften anxiety and turn the process into a source of calm.

I called this method “negative recursion.” It works together with the psychological effect of permitting the “forbidden fruit,” which I have already described above.

Here it is necessary not merely to understand the process, but rather to exaggeratedly enjoy it through the attitude of **“I don’t want to.”**

Paradoxically, at the moment of allowing yourself to smoke it is important not simply to give in to the craving and “permit yourself to smoke,” **but to deliberately exaggerate and savor the process.**

Consciously pay attention to the taste, the smell, the bitterness of the smoke, its stench, and its effect on the brain. Try to deliberately “enjoy” smoking.

With excessive contemplation, negative recursion is triggered: the cigarette ceases to be a source of desire and pleasure, revealing its true unpleasantness. For the subconscious it ceases to be the “forbidden fruit,” and the craving gradually dissipates.

This approach destroys the illusion of nicotine’s attractiveness. You allow yourself an episode without guilt, but at the same time you strip the cigarette of its aura.

It becomes not an object of desire, but a subject of observation — almost a laboratory specimen that you examine in detail.

I will tell you how it looked for me. I played a “game” with my “want” — for an hour, sometimes even three. When I reached the necessary limit, I would take out a cigarette and at first spend some time simply studying it: inhaling the smell of tobacco, rolling it between my fingers. Then I lit it and slowly took a deep drag, fixing in memory every nuance I received at that moment.

And there was not a single moment when this process truly pleased me. It was stinking, bitter, and astringent. Nothing like what I had always expected to feel.

This was precisely the paradox: the more attentively I “enjoyed” smoking, the faster it lost all appeal.

Thus, “enjoyment” turns into an instrument of indifference.

You do not fight, do not suffer, do not forbid yourself — on the contrary, you allow the episode, but make it so conscious that the subconscious itself rejects the illusion of pleasure.

The key skill that must be achieved is indifference.

The result of all the principles of the method is to form the habit of indifference to nicotine. It is not a struggle and not a prohibition, but a state in which the cigarette ceases to be significant.

Indifference is the final point, when you can light a cigarette and not feel that you have betrayed yourself.

Because the craving no longer controls you.

It is not stoic rejection and not heroic efforts of “not looking at smokers” or “not breathing the smoke.” **Indifference does not require tension; it is not connected with martyrdom.** It comes when the cigarette ceases to be an event, ceases to occupy a place in the system of values.

Unfortunately, many people striving to quit smoking believe that complete restriction from any mention of cigarettes will help them cope with the affliction. But it is precisely here that the paradox arises: **the more prohibitions, the greater the torment.** And when even the slightest mention or scent appears, this unfortunate person experiences real suffering, as if the world had betrayed his efforts.

Moreover, many who have “quit” through torment begin to openly despise and hate their former companions in misfortune. They turn their own refusal into a banner, raise it as a symbol of superiority, and demand that others follow the same path of suffering. In their consciousness, quitting smoking becomes not liberation but a new form of dependence — dependence on the feeling of being right.

But indifference is free of this poison.

It is calm and free.

It does not require proof, does not seek confirmation, and does not elevate a person above others.

Indifference is the state in which the cigarette is no longer the “forbidden fruit,” no longer a symbol of struggle or victory. It becomes an empty object, stripped of its aura and its power over you.

This is exactly where all three principles lead: recognition, working through relapses, and learning to enjoy the process. Together they form a single system with no place for heroism, prohibitions, or drama. What remains is the path to indifference — simple, calm, and final liberation.

And here is the most unsettling truth: someone who has truly quit can stand beside smokers and feel no tension.

More than that, a person who has genuinely quit can even smoke a cigarette calmly — without anxiety, without shame, and without any sense of betrayal. This is not provocation, but a confirmation of what indifference means. For someone who has quit, the habit belongs to the past, and it no longer holds any power.

Someone who has quit can breathe tobacco smoke without worry and even take it in calmly, because it no longer carries the meaning of dependence. It becomes an empty gesture, stripped of all power.

This state of indifference is true freedom. It is not a feat, not refusal for its own sake, not martyrdom, and not heroism. It is simply the absence of significance — the moment when the cigarette is no longer part of your life and fades into nothing.

Chapter 6. Step-by-Step Process

Attention! When quitting smoking, you don't need to change your environment, hide cigarettes, or avoid familiar places. Such "protection" only increases the significance of the habit and turns it into a forbidden fruit. Indifference is formed precisely in the natural environment — where smoking once happened, where the cigarette lies in plain sight, where the smell and ritual are familiar. A person learns to walk calmly past, to see the cigarette as an empty object, not as a challenge. This is not struggle and not avoidance, but gradual habituation to the absence of reaction. The environment becomes a training ground, not an enemy.

Additional requirements are not essential. What matters is to grasp the direction, understand the meaning, and let go of the phantom of false obligations and demands. There is no need to turn the process into bureaucracy — keeping a diary, writing reports, or ticking boxes. But if you are a methodical person used to control, step-by-step actions are available and can help structure the process.

1. Diagnosis of rituals

Record each moment when the urge to smoke appears: the time, the situation, the emotions, the surroundings. Write it down calmly, without judgment — the point is not to condemn yourself, but to observe. These notes make it possible to identify recurring scenarios: "a cigarette after a meal," "under stress," "in company." Such patterns reveal the key triggers that can be addressed either on your own or with a specialist. Diagnosis is not about control or reporting, but a tool of awareness that helps you see the habit from the outside.

2. Replacement of rituals

Instead of a cigarette, choose pre-planned actions: take a deep breath, drink a glass of water, go for a short walk, or replace the cigarette with dried fruit, a piece of candy, or any other method described below. That is why it is important to understand your priorities and desires, so you can select substitutions that naturally fit your lifestyle. This builds new habits and gradually replaces the old ones.

Rituals play a major role in quitting smoking — from everyday morning routines to social and cultural practices. They are precisely what create the stable associations that keep the addiction in place.

Even small changes can turn out to be important.

For example, I deliberately started adding milk to my coffee, changing the familiar ritual of the first cup. Earlier I disliked milk while smoking — it felt rough, like sandpaper on the tongue, and the taste was unpleasant. Yet this very “unpleasantness” helped delay the first cigarette: the familiar ritual of coffee with a cigarette was broken, and smoking was postponed until I left the house. It may seem minor, but it is precisely such conscious changes that show how replacing a ritual can alter the usual pattern.

3. Acceptance of the framework of multiplicity

Reject the illusion of “willpower” and the idea of a single decisive breakthrough. Approach the process as a series of attempts, where each recorded craving becomes part of the statistics. This is not defeat, but data that reveal the dynamics and make progress visible.

Multiplicity is the natural way to form a new habit: steps build into movement, and movement is always stronger than stagnation.

Real willpower lies in gradual, step-by-step striving toward the goal.

4. Acceptance of the inevitable

If you smoke, you are already mature enough to recognize that even a single cigarette causes harm. The medical phrase “every cigarette is a small stroke” sounds harsh, but it conveys the idea of irreversible damage from each episode.

Awareness of this harm is not intimidation, but a sober context in which decisions are made.

Study medical sources and materials on the risks and consequences of smoking — they are a powerful tool for awareness.

Information, combined with the practice of indifference, acts as an amplifier: you do not burden yourself with fear, but you clearly see the cost of the habit and stop romanticizing it.

In combination with the method of negative recursion (“enjoyment of the forbidden fruit”), awareness of the real harm becomes part of observation: you consciously register the taste, the smell, the bitterness, while at the same time holding the thought of the consequences. As a result, the cigarette loses its halo of pleasure and turns into a source of discomfort — both physical and moral.

5. Tracking the process

The main task is to grasp the principle of quitting. It is not a leap and not a feat, but a series of dozens — or even hundreds — of attempts that build into movement.

With this approach, changes happen almost imperceptibly, as if nothing is shifting. Yet it is precisely in this “imperceptibility” that the strength lies: the habit gradually loses its power, and indifference takes its place.

Such changes may appear through unexpected and unpleasant sensations: sudden fear, slight dizziness, or even a panic attack. It is important not to dramatize — consult a doctor to rule out medical causes. If the tests are normal, these reactions most often reflect an internal restructuring: the subconscious resists because the familiar ritual is collapsing. This is not a catastrophe, but a sign of the depth of the process.

In my case, part of the restructuring was a sudden loss of balance and a feeling of shortness of breath. These states came unexpectedly, as if the ground were slipping away beneath my feet and I had to lean on something or sit down. Along with them came a sense of irrational horror — not tied to external circumstances, but arising from within.

This is how the conflicting subconscious reveals itself.

It is important to remember: this is an individual experience, not a universal symptom. Each person’s process will differ, and psychiatry emphasizes that such reactions do not appear in everyone and may vary greatly.

The key is to treat these manifestations calmly. They are not enemies, but signs that the process is going deeper than it seems. If you record such symptoms, it means the habit is already losing its power, and indifference is gradually becoming the new norm.

Chapter 7. All Possible Working Methods

Attention! When quitting smoking, you don't need to change your environment, hide cigarettes, or avoid familiar places. Such "protection" only increases the significance of the habit and turns it into a forbidden fruit. Indifference is formed precisely in the natural environment — where smoking once happened, where the cigarette lies in plain sight, where the smell and ritual are familiar. A person learns to walk calmly past, to see the cigarette as an empty object, not as a challenge. This is not struggle and not avoidance, but gradual habituation to the absence of reaction. The environment becomes a training ground, not an enemy.

This chapter brings together a list of all the methods that have proven their effectiveness. Think of it as a constructor set.

They differ in form and approach, but they are united by one thing — working with the very structure of the habit.

Psychological Tricks and Methods

- **Devaluation of "strain" and "struggle"**

This is a method repeatedly emphasized in the book. It dismantles the aura of significance surrounding the cigarette and reduces it from any kind of symbol to an empty, harmful object.

Its purpose is to ensure that the smoker stops attaching special importance to the cigarette, nicotine, tobacco, the habit itself, and even the act of quitting. All of this must lose the aura of "specialness" and be seen as ordinary, empty, insignificant, and harmful.

Science shows that quitting smoking requires many attempts. To make the process effective and free of severe consequences, one must abandon misconceptions and myths about "immediacy," "willpower," and "heroism."

Slogans and calls for feats should be left to those who enjoy proclaiming them. The real path is the calm and honest dismantling of the myth, turning the cigarette into an empty object devoid of any meaning.

- **Delaying the process ("Bad Debtor Method"), more commonly known as the "Delayed Gratification Method"**

An effective technique for those not inclined to stoic endurance but who handle obstacles well in a playful way. Also described in the methodology, its essence is the conscious postponement of the moment of smoking, which disrupts the habitual scenario and reduces craving.

- **Negative Recursion ("Enjoying Smoking")**

This is one of the key methods for re-evaluating values in the process of changing a habit. Its essence is to give the act of smoking an exaggerated form of perception: through effort, through “I don’t want to,” slowly and deliberately “enjoying” each puff with all the senses.

It is especially effective in moments of relapse. It removes the feeling of betrayal, and most importantly, it dismantles the aura of value, breaking it down at the subconscious level.

Smoking is registered as a sequence of concrete sensations: a bitter, astringent taste, a sharp smell, physical discomfort during the act, and health consequences. As a result, the pathos and tension disappear, and the habit loses its entrenched image of significance.

- **Method “Conversation with the Brain” (Self-analysis)**

Sometimes the simplest way to cope with craving is not to fight it or forbid it, but to talk to yourself. When the brain starts demanding a cigarette, you don’t silence it — you answer: “Yes, I hear you. Shall we discuss this?”

Such inner dialogue can turn the command “smoke” into — though heavy — a conversation, where you set the rules yourself. You don’t destroy the illusion of pleasure directly, but translate it into negotiation.

With certain control skills, the brain stops being a dictator and becomes an interlocutor, one you can tell “wait” or even joke about its demand. The more often you engage in such dialogue, the faster the habit loses its power, and indifference forms naturally.

- **Medical Understanding of the Problem**

One of the most powerful triggers for quitting smoking is the realization of its actual harm to health. The situation is similar to “prohibitions”: many fail to see a direct connection, since a smoker’s death is attributed not to the cigarette itself but to its consequences — stroke, heart attack, cancer. Yet deeper understanding shows that consuming nicotine through smoke is an extremely dangerous act.

Author’s example: a CT scan immediately revealed spikes in blood pressure after each cigarette. This clearly demonstrates that the harm is not abstract, but concrete and measurable.

- **Support Groups**

Joint participation in quitting smoking allows people to share experiences, record successes, and support each other during relapses.

The strength of this method lies in collective energy: the habit stops being a personal drama and becomes a shared process. In the group, guilt and loneliness disappear, as everyone understands that relapses are part of the path, not a failure.

Here the principle of multiplicity works especially well — each participant sees that dozens of attempts by others are no different from their own, which normalizes the process.

Support groups reinforce indifference to the habit: when someone sees others calmly recording their relapses and continuing forward, the cigarette stops being a “forbidden fruit”

or a personal catastrophe. Instead, a calm attitude emerges: “I am not alone, we are all walking this path.” This relieves tension and turns quitting smoking into a collective skill.

Honesty is valued in such groups: everyone shares real steps, small victories, and setbacks, which cease to be drama and become part of the common statistics.

- **Companion**

A personal partner or close companion who goes through the process with you may be a friend, colleague, relative, or spouse. Their role is to carry the confidence of success. This is not mentorship. The essence of the method is not control, but psychological support without pressure or obligation. It creates the feeling of a shoulder nearby, removes loneliness, and makes the process feel natural.

Often this format proves stronger than any loud slogans or pompous declarations: when someone is beside you who does not demand, does not judge, but simply walks the path with you, indifference to the habit forms more quickly. The shared journey turns quitting smoking into a calm experience, where each step is recorded honestly and without dramatization.

- **Hypnosis**

The use of suggestion and work with the subconscious is a real method and can be highly effective, though it comes with certain nuances. Hypnosis may be risky for people with serious mental health issues, and ineffective for those who are not easily suggestible.

At the same time, a skilled hypnotist can literally switch off the habit — altering the perception of the cigarette and destroying its appeal at a deep level. For this reason, hypnosis cannot be called “controversial” in the sense of being fictitious: it works, but not for everyone, and requires caution.

- **Bets and Social Obligations**

A very effective method is making agreements with friends or colleagues: “if I smoke — I fulfill the condition.” It works through internal commitment and external stimulation, but most importantly, it helps to build indifference to the habit during frequent relapses, which is especially valuable.

The smoker reacts calmly to losing, fulfills the conditions honestly and without unnecessary emotion, turning each episode into a step toward indifference.

It is important to observe basic rules of safety, morality, and financial responsibility: do not bet large sums or valuables, and do not tie the agreement to immoral actions or breaking the law. It is better to use imagination and humor — inventing light, symbolic, or amusing conditions that motivate without creating pressure.

- **Allen Carr’s book “The Easy Way to Stop Smoking”**

Allen Carr created a guide that is genuinely powerful and, on a large scale, clearly effective: among many smokers, some do quit permanently. However, its central message is highly contradictory — “Smoke the last cigarette and never touch it again.”

At the end of the book, studies are presented that highlight the controversial nature of this method.

Still, I regard this work as a powerful yet flawed motivational tool, one that even influenced the author himself. Its strength lies in emotional preparation and psychological conditioning; its weakness lies in scientific reliability and poor long-term goal retention.

The book functions as a short-term psychological push — “once or twice.” It can provide an impulse and belief in the possibility of quitting. But scientific evidence clearly shows that lasting cessation requires gradual action, consistent behavioral restructuring, and the cultivation of indifference.

- **Motivational Lessons and Videos**

Doctors, scientists, psychologists, even comedians — all those who encourage quitting tobacco in their own way are suitable. The strength of such materials lies in their ability to create an emotional impulse, provide a fresh perspective, and help maintain short-term focus.

Videos and lectures act as an “injection of motivation”: they can provoke laughter, surprise, a sense of involvement, or even mild shock that temporarily repels from the cigarette.

Yet their value is not only emotional — they build a habit of constant reminders, of regular contact with the idea of quitting. This transforms the process into an informational environment where the cigarette gradually loses its status as a familiar companion.

It is important to remember: one should not trust “magic pill” narratives in the style of snake-oil selling, as such promises undermine focus and create false expectations of instant results.

Scientific data show that sustainable cessation is achieved through gradual behavioral restructuring, working with the brain’s biochemistry, and the consistent cultivation of indifference.

Therefore, motivational materials are useful as support — but only if they do not replace real work on the habit with the illusion of an easy miracle.

- **Attempt Counter**

A simple tool that tracks the number of postponed or skipped cigarettes. Even if the person smokes later, the counter still reflects progress — each reduction becomes a step toward indifference.

- **Micro-substitutions**

A sip of water, a breath, a brief note of a thought — small actions instead of the automatic drag.

- **Funny Absurdity**

Take a drag with a ridiculous gesture or an inner comment (“*another step added to the collection of foolishness*”). Yes, it sounds bizarre, but humor breaks the seriousness of the habit. I am not sure about its necessity.

- **Mini-bet with yourself**

Use imagination, create conditions. For example: “*If I endure another 10 minutes — I will eat a candy.*”

- **Moment Fixation**

Write down where and when the craving appeared. This turns the desire into an observable object rather than an automatism.

Physiological Methods

- **Breathing Exercises**

When a craving appears, taking a few slow breaths in and out can weaken its intensity. This simple act lowers stress and signals to the body: “I’ve already paused.” In some cases, breathing itself can replace the ritual of a cigarette — inhale, pause, exhale — only without nicotine.

There are many breathing practices that can be learned on your own. They calm the mind, sharpen focus, and restore energy.

One small but effective technique works like this: take a very deep breath through your nose, add a short, sharp “extra inhalation,” and then exhale fully. Usually once is enough, but it can be repeated. The lungs expand, the alveoli take in more air, the brain receives more oxygen, and anxiety visibly decreases.

The effect is straightforward and reliable. As a simple tool, this exercise interrupts the impulse, creates a pause, and step by step helps cultivate indifference to the habit.

- **The “Glass of Water” Method**

Sometimes the simplest action turns out to be the most effective. Drinking water in small sips is not only a mechanical substitute for a cigarette — when the mouth and hands are occupied — but also a physiological technique that helps to “wash away” the craving. The body receives a signal of renewal: the mucous membranes are moistened, the taste in the mouth changes, and the familiar scenario “*craving* → *light up*” is broken.

- **The “Snacks” Method and Its Secrets**

Certain drinks change the taste in such a way that smoking afterward becomes unpleasant. Milk, unsweetened green or black tea, and fresh juices create a clean, tart, or sour flavor in the mouth. This disrupts the usual ritual and makes the cigarette feel unnecessary.

Others, however, have the opposite effect and encourage smoking: coffee, Coca-Cola, kvass, fermented dairy products, and of course alcohol. These are historically tied to the habit and often trigger the familiar sequence — “sip → light up.”

Some products provoke craving, while others weaken it. Understanding this difference is a practical tool: you can choose what steers you away from nicotine and avoid what gives the habit another excuse.

- **The “Contrast Switching” Method**

Sometimes the craving for a cigarette lingers simply because the body is stuck in one state — sitting, thinking, waiting — and the familiar pattern is triggered automatically: “craving → cigarette.” But when the physical sensation changes sharply, the chain breaks. Splashing cold water on your face, stepping into fresh air, inhaling frost or wind — the body receives a clear signal: “the situation has changed.”

Research shows that such abrupt shifts activate the parasympathetic nervous system, which governs relaxation and recovery. As a result, stress decreases, habitual tension fades, and the urge to smoke weakens naturally. The body becomes occupied with adapting to the cold or the fresh air.

This works in the most ordinary settings — at home, at work, or on the road.

- **The “Stretching” Method**

This is a straightforward physiological technique that works through the body. Research shows that light stretches of the arms, back, or neck activate the parasympathetic nervous system — the system responsible for relaxation and recovery. As a result, stress decreases, muscle tension eases, and the familiar craving to “smoke to relieve tension” weakens.

The effect is not that stretching “replaces” the cigarette, but that it creates a pause and a shift. The body receives the signal: “I am already relaxed,” and the usual pattern is interrupted.

It is useful in the simplest situations — at work, at home, or while traveling. As a small tool, it works reliably: it releases tightness, gives the body a break, and step by step helps cultivate indifference to the habit.

- **Physical Activity**

Stand up, walk around, stretch, do a couple of squats, or simply loosen the shoulders. The brain shifts to movement, and the urge to smoke weakens.

Medical Intervention

It is important to be clear from the start: this is not my area of responsibility. I do not provide recommendations for pills, inhalers, or especially antidepressants. The information below is drawn

from publicly available sources, and anyone considering these options should consult a qualified specialist.

Nicotine Replacement Therapy (NRT):

- Nicotine gums
- Nicotine patches
- Nicotine lozenges
- Nicotine inhalers
- Nicotine sprays for mouth or nose

These agents provide the body with a dose of nicotine without a cigarette, gradually reducing dependence.

Non-nicotine medications:

- **Bupropion** (an antidepressant, known as *Zyban*) — reduces craving and eases withdrawal symptoms.
- **Varenicline** (*Chantix/Champix*) — acts on nicotine receptors, decreasing the pleasure of smoking and facilitating cessation.

Psychotropic and supportive agents:

- Antidepressants (other than bupropion) — sometimes prescribed for severe anxiety or depression related to quitting.
- Tranquilizers or mild sedative drugs — to relieve acute tension.
- Vitamins and adaptogens (for example, ginseng, magnesium) — as support for the body during the quitting period.

Specialized Medical Approaches:

- Hospitalization or stay in specialized clinics — in cases of severe dependence or combination with other mental disorders.
- Psychotherapy (cognitive-behavioral, group) — officially considered a medical tool, especially when combined with NRT.

Folk Remedies

Throughout the history of quitting smoking, there have always been “home remedies.” Some are passed down from grandmothers. They are not universal, and some can even be risky. Their real value lies in showing that people have always searched for ways to break the ritual of smoking — sometimes through absurd tricks, sometimes through deliberate aversion.

“Aversion” Methods

- **Cigarettes soaked in milk and dried.** After such treatment, the taste and smell become sharply unpleasant, causing aversion.
- **Cigarettes with foreign matter (for example, nail clippings).** Adding extraneous substances produces a strong odor and taste, breaking the usual ritual.
- **Special rinses (for example, made from wormwood or oats)** — create an unpleasant taste when smoking.

Herbal Therapy and Infusions

- **Oat decoction.** Considered a classic folk remedy: helps reduce craving and cleanse the body.
- **St. John's wort infusion.** Used to reduce anxiety and stabilize mood during cessation.
- **Wormwood, mint, valerian.** Herbs applied to lessen craving and relieve stress.
- **Tea from licorice root or plantain.** Sometimes recommended to create mild aversion to tobacco.

Extreme and Controversial Practices

- **Microdosing of the red fly agaric (muscimol).** Modern experiments view muscimol as a substance that influences the psyche and may reduce cravings for tobacco and alcohol. The author's personal experience confirms that muscimol was a strong aid in quitting alcohol. Smoking, however, was stopped earlier, independently and without its involvement.

It is scientifically established that muscimol acts on the GABA system — the brain's primary inhibitory mediator. It substitutes for the same mechanisms on which the effects of tobacco and alcohol depend. As a result, habitual signals lose their impact, and a state of indifference emerges: cravings diminish, and the habit weakens.

Research on muscimol is ongoing, exploring its effects on anxiety, epilepsy, cognitive processes, and neuroprotection.

Its legal status is also significant internationally: in Australia, muscimol is officially classified as a narcotic substance and is prohibited.

It must be stressed once again: muscimol is a relatively new psychoactive compound. Moderate doses cause intoxication, while higher doses can be dangerous. The author does not encourage its use. The information is presented solely for documentary purposes, with reference to its legal status and associated risks.

- **Long-term stay in clinics or “folk clinics”**

In some groups and communities, isolation is believed to help break the habit. The actual effect is unknown.

Chapter 8. How the Everyday Miracle Happens

Many people wonder: “What actually happens at the moment of quitting smoking?”

One person described it this way: “I didn’t even realize how it happened. I just noticed in the evening that I hadn’t smoked all day.” And yet, for almost a year before that, at every meeting he would say the same thing: “*I smoked again.*”

Each time I answered: “Well done! If you want, smoke another. The main thing is not to worry or turn it into drama.”

It was precisely this absence of pressure that allowed his habit to fade on its own — not through heroism, not through prohibition, but through indifference, which gradually displaced dependence.

My own experience was different. About two years earlier, while walking to kindergarten to pick up my daughter, I took out a cigarette and, for the first time in my life, looked at it with incomprehension.

It was striking to realize that smoking was not part of my life, but a foreign and harmful element to which I had given not only time and money, but also my health — and the health of my family and loved ones.

At that moment, looking at the cigarette, I felt only rejection, mixed with surprise: quitting had happened much faster than I had expected.

I looked at that “last” cigarette with the thought: “*It seems I’ve finally quit.*” Yet I chose to smoke it — along with the rest of the pack. Not for pleasure, but out of rejection and indifference.

Interestingly, the realization of quitting was not joyful, but dull in its ordinariness — simply a recognition of reality. No “solemn music,” no catharsis. Only my wife’s skeptical question in the evening brought me back to the subject: “*Did you really not smoke today? You don’t smell of cigarettes.*”

I smiled, took out a cigarette, and with a sense of *not wanting* went to “finish the pack.” And that was all.

And it was at that moment that Emptiness entered my life. From then on, I could no longer work in the usual way: for every thought that once required reflection, I would step outside with a cigarette. Everyday rituals disappeared, social ties dissolved, and the number of contacts and new acquaintances dropped sharply.

A huge part of my former life vanished — instantly, in a single moment.

If you quit gradually, such Emptiness may not appear: withdrawal happens step by step, and one day you simply notice you haven’t smoked all day. But in my case the cessation was abrupt, and that is why I felt the break so sharply.

My family was joyfully surprised. Some acquaintances laughed skeptically and offered me a cigarette. I, teasing them in return, calmly took one, smoked it — and did not smoke again. That gesture broke the usual patterns and made some of them think.

I only explained to them what you are now reading.

*Quitting smoking is not a heroic feat. It is a path where indifference gradually displaces dependence, and long-standing rituals — even entire layers of life — dissolve. Each step is not about control or reporting, but about noticing how the habit steadily loses its power.

For some, withdrawal comes through repeated attempts; for others, through a sudden break and the experience of Emptiness. Yet the outcome is always the same: the cigarette ceases to be part of life. And this is precisely where the strength of the method lies.

As I have already said, there are two most likely scenarios: gradual and abrupt.

- **Gradual cessation.** *People with a more consistent temperament and organized psyche quit smoking almost imperceptibly. Everything unfolds naturally, because the mind has time to adjust to long stretches without cigarettes.*
- **Abrupt cessation.** The craving for cigarettes shuts off suddenly. Just yesterday you were ready to dash into the night because only two were left in the pack — and suddenly, Bang! — you are holding one and don't know what to do with it. In front of you lies a repulsive, alien object, and the thought of using it provokes only one question: “*Am I an idiot?*”

I don't think it is necessary to list in detail the benefits of quitting smoking. It all comes down to one simple fact: you stop caring. To the point of absurdity — indifference displaces the significance of the habit.

Yet there is an important nuance: as in my case, some may experience Emptiness. At that moment, much time is freed, new resources appear — and they need to be filled with something. As my personal experience showed, this can itself become a source of stress.

Psychologists recommend using this period to form new habits and interests, to broaden horizons both culturally and physically. Here it is important to rely solely on personal priorities: for some it may be sports, running, or walking; for others — drawing, photography, music, or reading. The essence is simple: Emptiness must be filled with activities that bring pleasure and strengthen inner resilience.

In the first weeks I enjoyed the sheer fact of freedom: no more stepping outside every hour. I simply stayed at home, watched movies, played games, and read books — my own way of filling the time and living through the first days without cigarettes.

Another feature of quitting, beyond the unusual behavioral rituals, is the reaction of those around you.

Most often these are positive wishes and genuine joy. Quite often there are responses of mild or friendly envy. And inevitably, someone will subject your achievement to skepticism or even criticism. This is a common stance among those who call themselves “realists.” Even well-meaning people may show distrust and try to test you “for weakness.”

Here a special nuance emerges: quitting smoking does not mean never touching a cigarette again. Someone who has truly quit can calmly take a cigarette, light it, and meet the eyes of the “realist” without the slightest tension.

Indifference is the true sign of cessation: the cigarette loses its power, ceases to be an event.

If you still feel the pull — if emotions arise inside such as anger, panic, or a sense of betrayal — it means the process is not yet complete. This is an honest signal: there is still work to do, steps to take, and perhaps setbacks to face. But acknowledging this fact shows that you are on the path, not trapped in illusion.

Naturally, once you quit, you should not inhale cigarette smoke against your will. What I have described is the state of someone truly freed from dependence. It is the feeling of indifference: the cigarette ceases to be an event, ceases to hold power.

True cessation does not require demonstrations or proofs. It shows itself in your life, in the simple fact that you no longer build it around the cigarette.

The essential thing is not heroism, but the ability to see the direction and move toward the goal slowly, steadily, yet relentlessly. Then quitting is no longer a struggle, but a natural liberation.

Chapter 9. Honesty and Ethical Principles

Let us recall another fundamentally important detail that helps achieve results not only in something as seemingly mundane as quitting smoking, but also in more serious aspects of life. It concerns the ethical side of the issue — more precisely, honesty toward oneself and one's own capabilities.

Honesty with oneself is not an embellishment of the process, but its foundation.

There is a simple wisdom: ***“Self-deception is punished by life itself.”***

From this it follows that whatever you strive for, you must always have a clear understanding of the final result, the goal, and the completion of the plan. Self-deception becomes the greatest danger: it turns your efforts into walking in circles of your own lies.

Honesty is not about beautiful words, but about seeing reality as it truly is.

Therefore, if you declare to everyone: *“I am quitting smoking,”* conscientiously read this method, and even feel the desire — but at the same time do not work, do not make yourself exert effort, and only “enjoy” — then you should not be surprised if instead of one hundred and forty attempts you end up with five hundred or even a thousand failed starts.

This is precisely the principle voiced by Albert Einstein: *“Insanity is doing the same thing over and over again, expecting different results.”* Naturally, this does not mean that such repetition is connected with mental problems or failures in brain physiology. But the quotation accurately conveys the nature of self-deception — the appearance of action with a complete absence of real movement.

And, as always, we cannot bypass the central idea of this method — the individualization of recognition and honesty. The thought may seem obvious, and most will grasp it immediately. Yet there are those accustomed to living in self-deception, like an organism content with stagnant water, without movement.

It is not difficult to recognize this. If you easily and often resort to dishonest methods — whether in computer games, in sports, at work, or in relationships — it is the same behavioral pattern.

There are people who like to cheat, bypass rules, or manipulate, believing it gives them an advantage. In reality, it is nothing more than a habit of living in illusion. In games this is called cheating, and because of such players the entire process is spoiled: others despise them, the atmosphere collapses, and the game itself loses meaning.

But in life the consequences are far more serious. Where in a game the atmosphere collapses, in reality trust collapses. In games it is cheating, but in life it is betrayal. And for deception, people pay not only with their reputation, but sometimes with their lives.

This habit gradually turns into a system: a person deceives himself again and again — in the best case. In the worst, he destroys his own life and the lives of others.

Let me emphasize once more: clinical cases are not considered here. The focus is on everyday illusion — when someone tells himself: *“I don't smoke, I only enjoy, as prescribed.”* In reality this

is the same trap as many other delusions, where the outer shell hides inner emptiness. It is a form of self-deception, where inaction is masked by beautiful words, and the absence of real effort is replaced by the appearance of process.

Such “enjoyment” becomes a convenient excuse: it seems as if there is movement, but in fact no steps are taken. And the longer a person clings to this illusion, the more firmly it turns into a habit — a habit of living in self-deception, where words replace actions and desire substitutes for labor.

When you quit smoking, make commitments to yourself.

In cultivating indifference, it is important to understand that these commitments and principles do not require complex moral dilemmas, suffering, or proof to others.

Their strength lies in simplicity — in gradual work, in honest acknowledgment of one’s own mistakes, and, most importantly, in preserving personal **self-respect**.

Self-respect becomes the main criterion: you do not justify yourself, do not look for detours, do not invent “softening” formulations. You record honestly where you failed, where you made mistakes, and you continue moving forward. This is the true ethics of the process — not the illusion of victory, but real work on oneself.

In essence, everything here is about cultivating honesty and self-respect. These are qualities that cannot be taken from a shelf or inherited; they can only be developed and reinforced — calmly and with determination.

The methods and approaches are now your own work. Here, you become the architect of your own process. For those accustomed to expecting others to do the work for them, a crucial reminder: do not deceive yourself. An adult takes responsibility and does the work themselves.

This book is free, and there is no obligation to pay. But if you feel it has become part of your journey and you wish to honestly support the work that made it possible, you can do so here:

[Science of Indifference — Marat Bekmurzaev](#)

The choice remains yours, just as this entire process does.

Chapter 10. Statistical Argumentation

Attention!

In longitudinal cohort studies (long-term observation of the same group of people), a “successful quitter” is defined as someone who, after giving up cigarettes, has not smoked for 12 consecutive months. This criterion is known as “continuous abstinence” — the absence of substance use without interruption.

Yet real life shows that this measure does not capture the full picture: many smokers may return to the habit after a year, or even several years later.

Therefore, the figures presented should be understood as conditional statistical benchmarks — simplified reference points rather than ultimate truth. Within this methodology, we reinterpret such data to reflect the real process: relapse, repeated attempts, multiplicity, and gradual movement toward indifference.

Method 1 (based on the recollections of successful smokers): the average value is about 6.3 attempts.

This calculation method is built on the fact that researchers studied only those who had quit, asking them how many times they had tried before.

The resulting figure is an average, but it is immediately distorted:

first, the sample does not include those who never managed to quit — their multiple attempts simply disappear from the statistics;

second, the data are based on human memory, and memory poorly records the number of repetitive events over many years.

As a result, the figure looks “small” and optimistic, but in reality it reflects only the experience of those who succeeded, and even in a shortened form. Therefore, this method systematically underestimates the real number of attempts, creating the illusion that quitting smoking is easier than it actually is.

Method 2: constant probability of success (≈19.6 attempts)

Logic: in this model, each attempt is considered independent and has the same chance of success. Researchers from Toronto took the overall probability of success across all observed attempts — about 5.1% — and substituted it into a simple formula:

number of attempts

$$\frac{1}{p}, p \approx 0.051$$

As a result, the outcome was ≈ 19.6 attempts.

The problem is that in reality attempts are not identical. Those who quit easily leave at the early stages, while the more “difficult” cases remain, and their chance decreases with each new attempt.

Another nuance: in this model, “success” is considered final if a person has not smoked for a year. But many return to cigarettes after a year, and even after several years. Thus, the figure of 19.6 looks optimistic, but in fact it underestimates the real picture.

Conclusion: Method 2 produces an attractive number, but it does not reflect real life.

Averaged data, where the “easy quitters” are counted as final winners, distort the statistics. The reality is that most people will have to go through dozens of attempts before indifference to nicotine becomes stable.

Method 3: life-table, observed data (≈ 29.6 attempts)

Data source: only the observed attempts during the study period (2005–2011). The study includes all current smokers who tried to quit during the observation period.

What is excluded: people who had quit permanently before the start of the study.

Logic: here the dynamics of probability are taken into account — the chance of success depends on the number of the attempt.

First attempt: $\approx 11\%$ success (one year without cigarettes).

Second attempt: $\approx 5\%$.

After that — even less.

The “life-table” (survival table) is used: just as in demography the probability of living to a certain age is calculated, here the probability of quitting on a particular attempt is calculated.

Formula for the first attempt:

$$p_1 \approx 0.11$$

where **p1** is the probability of lasting a year without cigarettes on the first attempt.

For the second attempt:

$$[p_2 \approx 0.05]$$

After that, the probability $[p_k]$ decreases even more.

The average number of attempts until success is calculated as the “area under the survival curve”:

$$[E[N] \approx 29.6]$$

where:

E[N] — the expected (average) number of attempts until successful smoking cessation;

the value 29.6 was obtained from the analysis of the “life-table” (survival table), built on the basis of 1277 smokers from the Ontario Tobacco Survey.

Scientists calculated the “area under the survival curve” (similar to how in demography the average life expectancy is calculated).

This gives an average number of attempts ≈ 29.6 , which reflects the real multiplicity of the process: most smokers make dozens of attempts before indifference to nicotine becomes stable.

Method 4 (life-table + recollections of past attempts): ≈ 142 attempts.

Data source: observed attempts during the study period (2005–2011) plus participants’ recollections of all past attempts made before entering the study.

What is excluded: people who had quit permanently before the start of the study (easy cases). The sample includes only those who continued smoking and had a long history of unsuccessful attempts.

Logic: this method takes into account not only the dynamics of probability based on observed data, but also adds the “background” from recollections.

At the start, each participant reports how many times they had tried to quit before.

These past attempts are added to the new ones observed during the study.

Then a “life-table” (survival table) is constructed, where the probability of success is calculated based on the total number of attempts.

Formula:

$$E[N] \approx 142$$

where:

E[N] — the expected (average) number of attempts until successful smoking cessation;

the value 142 was obtained from the analysis of the “life-table” (survival table), built on the basis of 1277 smokers from the Ontario Tobacco Survey, taking into account their recollections of past attempts.

Specific feature of the method: It overestimates the result because it excludes those who quit earlier and permanently.

The sample includes only the “difficult” smokers, whose number of attempts is large.

Recollections of past attempts are often incomplete, but still increase the final number.

Conclusion: Method 4 shows the “upper boundary” — how many attempts may be required for the most difficult smokers.

This is not a universal number for everyone, but rather a reflection that for some people the process may stretch into hundreds of attempts.

Thus, Method 4 complements Method 3: if Method 3 gives a realistic average (≈ 29.6), then Method 4 shows an extreme scenario (≈ 142), when all past — even minor — failures are taken into account.

Correct conclusion

- **Failures are part of the process.**
- **Most smokers make dozens of attempts.**
- **This is normal: statistics confirm that the path to indifference is multiple.**

As you can see, statistics dismantle the myth of “willpower.” They reveal that quitting smoking is not a one-time heroic act, but honest work carried out through multiple attempts. It is precisely multiplicity that leads to indifference — and indifference, in turn, to freedom.

Final chapter

This chapter serves as the conclusion of the entire book. It is intended not only for the smoker, but for anyone who wants to understand how determination truly works. Yet before moving on to the universal model, it is worth pausing on one important nuance.

Have you ever considered that there may be no more influential PR manager for the tobacco industry than the so-called Allen Carr?

This is not an exaggeration, but a fact supported by observation: his advertising slogans sound exactly as corporations dream of instilling in every smoker — quit easily, without gaining weight, without effort, without pain. And when it does not work, the message becomes: quitting is impossible. After all, according to his own words, it must be done immediately, “in one stroke.”

And here arises the real trap: a person tries, fails, and returns to cigarettes already convinced that he will remain a smoker forever. This is not merely a return to the habit — it is a capitulation, profitable to the industry.

Yet the entire book, along with the studies referenced at the end, proves the opposite: quitting is not only possible, but real. Moreover, with a certain determination it can even be done easily.

Failure does not mean “forever.” On the contrary, each unsuccessful attempt is a step toward success — provided you do not stop and do not abandon your striving.

It is precisely from the misunderstanding of this multiplicity that myths are born, feeding the quack methodologists: **they sell promises, not results**. The essence here is not in exposing dishonest motivators, but in the very model of priority distribution.

When we stop believing in miraculous promises and waiting for someone else to do the work for us, and instead begin to take seriously the change of habits, our health, and our life — it is exactly then that we regain our strength and our right to decide.

And this is the main conclusion of the book: quitting smoking, or changing any other habit, is possible if the process is regarded as a path of calm and conscious determination, not as an instant miracle.

Habit as foundation

Any goal rests on habit. Our entire life is a chain of habits, rituals, and endless repetitions. Any novelty brings stress — sometimes pleasant, sometimes heavy.

For example, a new romantic connection is always experienced as a unique moment, filled with happiness hormones and joyful expectations. But if someone begins to seek such connections only for the surge of hormones and adrenaline, the uniqueness disappears, and

the process turns into routine — into a habit that no longer carries meaning, but merely serves the need of the newly acquired habit.

Breakfast is a habit. Taking the bus before work is a habit. Weekdays, weekends, holidays, acquaintances, friends, superiors, and life itself — all of this is 90% composed of the routine actions we perform unconsciously.

The remaining 10% consists of natural processes tied to safety, control of time, speed, and distance

This routine is what many coaches call the “comfort zone,” from which one supposedly must “exit” in order to achieve success. Most often, however, what they mean is not comfort, but the disruption of the usual order through negativity, endurance, and patience.

Here context is crucial — something motivators and coaches often forget. Slogans and motivational pathos frequently clash with the logic and beauty of everyday life. After all, any striving for something is a basic desire, and a “comfort zone” can arise even after three months of sitting in a pit, bound in shackles.

Do you want to learn something? For example, to cook lasagna at the level of a chef. Or to ride a snowboard with confidence. To achieve this, you will have to cook lasagna dozens or hundreds of times, fall from the board hundreds or even thousands of times — and each time repeat the same actions.

And it is necessary to accept that at first everything will go badly, no matter how hard you try. This is normal: any skill begins with mistakes and failures, and only through them is habit formed.

- **A habit is not automatism, but the “skeleton” of purposeful activity.**

It is reinforced by the striving to achieve a result, relying on involvement, passion, and that very talent.

If you strive only because it is a matter of survival or earning money, then you will simply acquire the skill of cooking good pasta or of confidently staying on the board. Such a skill remains purely utilitarian.

But if you begin to enjoy experimenting with presentation, interest arises, and each new action brings pleasure. Then the skill becomes not only qualitative but also effortless. Any outside observer will say that you definitely have talent.

Conditionally, if you decide to start doing something at the beginning of the week, then right away out of 100 attempts you will make 99 mistakes. By the evening there will already be 98. By midweek you will be making 90–95 mistakes. You will always be making mistakes. You will be making mistakes in everything.

With smoking, it is exactly the same situation.

Universality of the process

Quitting cigarettes follows the very same mechanics: first small steps, then repetition, and then consolidation. Gradually and routinely. Making mistakes — without getting upset. Working — without stopping.

If something does not work out, here you do not risk spoiling a dish or breaking a limb. Reward yourself with a nicotine dose, applying the methodical approach of “exaggerated savoring” — or negative recursion — and then start again.

Let me note an important aspect: to replace a habit, you do not need to break your environment and space, as some advise — “remove irritants, and it will become easier for you.” No! On the contrary, for consolidating a skill it is necessary to have as many irritants and triggers as possible. Just as a future chef must see the fire, taste the dish, and feel its volume, or a snowboarder must face numerous obstacles and difficult sections.

As you can see, this principle applies in sports, study, business, and creativity. It was the same principle when we learned to walk, to speak, and to write. With only one small difference.

- **The essence is not in struggle, but in re-tuning: the old habit is replaced by a new one.**

Smoking is an acquired habit, reinforced by cultural and social factors and aggravated by the biochemical influence on the body. In most cases, we began smoking not out of necessity, but for idle reasons or company. And once inside this circle, we suddenly discovered that leaving it is far more difficult than entering. Especially when the public narrative, offering a solution, begins to “play” with vague slogans.

“Here” and “right now” — this is more like a hysterical demand to immediately leave a difficult snowboard track or to instantly apply for a Michelin star. Meanwhile, doctors, psychologists, and guru-motivators confidently declare that this is the necessary and only way: a way of struggle and endurance.

Yet there is a simple and natural path — the path of changing a habit, with an understanding of the essence of the problem. Yes, it is long. Yes, it provokes irritation and psychological discomfort when something does not work out. But it is the same work of acquiring a skill as any other: the Monday blues while practicing a difficult trick, or listening to the complaints of a picky restaurant client.

The only difference between this method and acquiring the mastery of a chef or an athlete is that the smoking habit is not consolidated, but leaves. It ceases to control behavior.

General conclusion

*The methodology of quitting smoking in *The Science of Indifference* is not a private case, but a textbook on habit formation in general.

It demonstrates that determination is born not from slogans or instant miracles, but from honesty, repetition, and gradual progress. Mistakes are inevitable — and it is precisely they that form the essence of the result.

- **Smoking here is only a model.**

The point is that any habit can be re-tuned: the old one fades, the new one takes root. And precisely in this lies the universal mechanism of change. If the process is approached as a path of calm and conscious work, then quitting smoking, learning to cook, mastering a sport, or building a career — all of these follow the same logic. The logic of small steps and repetitions that accumulate into a result.

And the main conclusion of the book is simple: habit is the foundation of any goal. Which means that by changing a habit, we change life.

With respect, I shake your hand. I am confident that you will cope easily.

Marat Bekmurzaev.

Scientific studies and sources on which the methodology is based:

[Estimating the number of quit attempts it takes to quit smoking successfully in a longitudinal cohort of smokers | BMJ Open](#) — University of Toronto, Johns Hopkins, Ontario Tobacco Research Unit.

Study details

- Authors: Michael Chaiton, Lori Diemert, Joanna E. Cohen, Susan J. Bondy, Peter Selby, Anne Philipneri, Robert Schwartz.
- Journal: BMJ Open, Volume 6, Issue 6, Article e011045 (2016).
- Purpose: to clarify the number of attempts required for successful smoking cessation, using data from a longitudinal study (Ontario Tobacco Survey).
- Methodology: observation of 1277 participants who attempted to quit smoking, with regular surveys every 6 months over 3 years.
- Conclusion: the number of attempts before successful cessation varies depending on the counting method, but on average many attempts (often dozens) are required before a person finally quits smoking.
- This study became an important argument against the myth “*quit instantly*” — it shows that failures are part of the process, not proof of impossibility.

[Smoking Habits Stable; Most Would Like to Quit](#) — Gallup Poll (2006)

Key facts from the study

- Year of publication: 2006.
- Source: Gallup News Service.
- Conclusion: according to the survey, former smokers on average made 6.1 attempts before they managed to quit permanently.
- This figure is often cited in literature and smoking cessation programs as the “average number of attempts,” although it is based on self-reports and, as researchers note, may be underestimated due to memory issues and the exclusion of those who never quit.
- Thus, Gallup (2006) provides a more “optimistic” number (about 6 attempts), whereas later longitudinal studies, for example BMJ Open (2016), show that the real number may be significantly higher — 20–30 or more attempts.

Tobacco Use Statistics — Canada.ca Canadian Tobacco Use Monitoring Survey (CTUMS), with data on the number of quit attempts among former smokers.

Essence of the study

- CTUMS was conducted annually from 1999 to 2012, covering the Canadian population aged 15 and older.
- Main purpose — to track the dynamics of smoking and quit attempts, especially among youth aged 15–24.
- Key result: in different years, about half of smokers reported making at least one attempt to quit smoking in the past 12 months.
- Among former smokers it was recorded that successful cessation usually required several attempts — most often from 5 to 7, which is consistent with Gallup (2006) data and other international surveys.
- Important: CTUMS shows that unsuccessful attempts are part of the process, and it is precisely their accumulation that leads to final success.
- Thus, CTUMS confirms the general picture: quitting smoking rarely happens *instantly*. Most former smokers went through multiple attempts before the habit ceased to control their behavior.

Individual-level predictors of cessation behaviours among participants in the International Tobacco Control (ITC) Four Country Survey | Tobacco Control

Essence of the study

- The ITC Four Country Survey (USA, Canada, United Kingdom, Australia) showed that most smokers make multiple attempts to quit, and the likelihood of success depends on age, level of dependence, and social support.

Conclusion

- Smoking cessation is a process that requires repeated attempts, not a single effort.

Age as a predictor of quit attempts and quit success in smoking cessation: findings from the International Tobacco Control Four-Country Survey (2002–14) — ITC Project

Essence

- ITC data (2002–2014) showed that younger smokers make quit attempts more often but achieve success less frequently. Older age groups make fewer attempts but have a higher likelihood of permanent cessation.

Conclusion

- The dynamics of cessation depend on age — younger smokers try more often, while older smokers are more likely to consolidate the result.

How much unsuccessful quitting activity is going on among adult smokers? Data from the International Tobacco Control Four Country cohort survey — King's College London

Essence of the study

- This is a large, long-term study conducted in Australia, Canada, the United Kingdom, and the United States. More than 21,000 smokers participated and were surveyed over several years.
- Essence: analysis of 7 waves of ITC-4, meaning that researchers collected data from seven consecutive survey waves (each wave being a new round of interviews with the same sample). Such a design makes it possible to track the dynamics of the same individuals' behavior over time.
- The study showed that among adult smokers there is an enormous number of unsuccessful attempts. Most participants tried to quit several times, but only a small fraction achieved lasting success.

Conclusion

- The process of smoking cessation is characterized by a high frequency of failures, which confirms the need to regard them as part of the path, not as defeat.

Critical studies of Allen Carr's methodology

[Allen Carr's Easyway to Stop Smoking — A randomised clinical trial | Tobacco Control](#)

Essence

- A comparison was conducted between Allen Carr's method and other smoking cessation programs.

Result

- Some participants did quit smoking, but the outcomes did not exceed those of standard methods (for example, NHS programs).

Criticism

- The effect exists, but it is not unique and not higher than traditional approaches.
-

[The effectiveness of Allen Carr's method for smoking cessation: A systematic review](#)

Essence

- All available studies on Carr's method were collected.

Result

- The evidence base is limited and heterogeneous. Some studies note a positive effect, but methodological weaknesses (small samples, lack of long-term follow-up) do not allow it to be considered reliable.

Criticism

- The method is popular, but there is no scientific proof of its superiority over other approaches.

[Study protocol for a randomised controlled trial of Allen Carr's Easyway programme versus Lambeth and Southwark NHS for smoking cessation | BMJ Open](#)

Essence

- An officially registered randomized study in which Carr's method was compared with NHS smoking cessation programs.

Result

- The protocol emphasizes the need for strict testing, since previous data were too weak.

Criticism

- The very fact that an RCT was required shows that the method does not have a sufficient evidence base.

NG209 Evidence Review P

Essence

- The popularity of the method is explained by its simplicity and the promise of “ease.”

Result

- Scientific data show that an effect is possible, but it is no higher than other programs.

Main problem

- The absence of long-term evidence and weak research methodology.

Criticism

- National guidelines (for example, NICE) do not include Carr’s method in the list of recommended approaches, considering it insufficiently evidenced.